

Career Transition Intake Form

Round 1 Feedback Report

Testers: Jean Onyango · Aida · Additional tester

Date: 10–11 July 2026 | Prepared by: Eric Gitonga

1. Overview

This report synthesises feedback from two testers who reviewed and attempted to complete the Career Transition intake form at *career-transition-intake.onrender.com* on 10 July 2026. Jean Onyango completed a full walkthrough and documented her responses and observations inline (printed to PDF after the form failed to submit). Aida reviewed the form and provided a written UX summary.

The findings are grouped into six categories: a critical technical bug that prevented submission entirely; form flow issues where question sequencing confused testers; a missing question identified by Jean; a section title that needs rewording; a scope/audience gap flagged by Aida; and a cold-start loading screen issue raised by an additional tester. Each finding includes a recommended fix, a priority rating, and implementation status.

2. Critical Bug — CSRF Token Invalidation on Server Restart

Source

Jean's feedback and server log from the Render deployment.

What happened

Jean opened the form at 11:31 UTC and spent approximately 15 minutes filling it in. At 11:46 UTC the Render instance was spun down (free-tier idle timeout). When Jean clicked Submit at 11:49 UTC the server had already restarted with a newly generated **SECRET_KEY**, invalidating her CSRF token. Every POST attempt returned HTTP 400. She tried ten times before giving up and printing the page to PDF instead.

Jean's exact words:

"The PDF generation did not happen. Gave the error: Error: <!doctype html> <html lang=en> <title>400 Bad Request</title> <h1>Bad Request</h1> <p>The CSRF session token is missing.</p> — The form refused to submit."

Root cause

The **SECRET_KEY** environment variable is not set in the Render dashboard. The app falls back to `secrets.token_hex(32)` on each startup, so every restart generates a new key and invalidates all outstanding CSRF tokens. On Render's free tier, instances spin down after 15 minutes of inactivity and restart on the next request — exactly the pattern that hit Jean.

Fix

Step	Action
1	Go to Render dashboard → <i>career-transition-intake</i> service → Environment → Add environment variable.
2	Set SECRET_KEY to a strong random value, e.g. output of <code>python -c "import secrets; print(secrets.token_hex(32))"</code> .
3	Trigger a manual redeploy so the new variable takes effect.
4	Verify: load the form, wait 20 minutes (to force a spin-down), reload, fill in and submit — should succeed.

Priority: CRITICAL

Blocked a real user from submitting entirely. No workaround exists for non-technical users. Must be resolved before the next tester session.

3. Form Flow Issue — Question Appears Before Its Subject

Source

Jean Onyango — inline feedback written into the form during her session.

What happened

In Section 2 (Motivation & Context), the form asks: *"What specifically attracts you to the target domain?"* This question appears **before** the user has been asked what their target domain is. The target domain field lives in Section 3 (Target Role Clarity). Jean could not answer meaningfully because no domain had been established yet.

Jean's exact words (written into the field):

"Here, you need to ask what the target domain is first, before asking what attracts me to it. This question should move to the target clarity role section."

Fix

Move *"What specifically attracts you to the target domain?"* from Section 2 to Section 3, placing it immediately **after** the *"Target domain / field"* input. The question becomes logical once the domain is established and the answer will be richer because the respondent has just named what they are targeting.

Priority: HIGH

Caused confusion for a first-time user and produced an unusable answer. The fix is a simple reorder — no new fields needed.

4. New Question — Target Organisation Lifecycle Stage

Source

Jean Onyango — written into the 'Roles / sectors explicitly ruled out' field in Section 3.

What was suggested

Jean's exact words (in the ruled-out field):

"Also ask a question around the life cycle stage of the target organization: Start-up, mid-[stage]..."

Why this matters

An applicant targeting a seed-stage startup needs a very different plan (equity literacy, tolerance for ambiguity, generalist skills) than one targeting a mature multilateral (compliance expertise, formal procurement, hierarchy navigation). Knowing the preferred lifecycle stage lets the plan tailor organisation targets in Section 2 and the skills gap analysis in Section 3 of the deliverable more precisely.

Proposed addition

Add a new multi-select field to Section 3 (Target Role Clarity), positioned after 'Preferred organisation types':

Proposed field label	Options
Preferred organisation stage (select all that apply)	Early-stage startup (seed / Series A) Growth-stage startup (Series B+) Established / mid-size organisation Large / mature organisation (1000+ staff) No preference

Priority: MEDIUM

Adds genuine value to the plan output and was requested by a tester organically. No form logic changes needed — it is a standalone multi-select.

5. Section Title Clarity — 'Deliverable Preferences'

Source

Jean Onyango — written into the 'Sections to emphasise' field.

Jean's exact words:

"This section on Deliverable Preferences is not clear to me, when I look at the title and the questions. Maybe re-word the title?"

Why the current title fails

The word 'deliverable' is consultant jargon that the client has not been introduced to at this point in the form. The questions in the section — who will see the plan, what to emphasise, background notes — are actually about how the plan should be framed and personalised, which is a more intuitive framing.

Recommended rename

Current title	Proposed title	Rationale
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9 Deliverable Preferences	9 About Your Plan	Plain language; directly describes the questions that follow (who sees it, what to highlight, what to handle with care).
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Priority: LOW

One-word change to index.html with no backend or logic impact. Worth doing alongside the other UX fixes.

6. Scope & Audience — Form Appears Corporate-Only

Source

Aida — written feedback summary.

Aida's exact words:

"So at first I thought it was only for those who are, who've been or who wish to join the job market but I can see you've included startup somewhere there as well so making it also open to those who are entrepreneurs or willing to get into that... Make sure to let those who wish to fill it know that it captures both those in the job market and those out of it. Because at first glance it looks like its only for the corporate world. For those who are in business and maybe wish to venture into a different one or expand, maybe keep the CV option open. Is that doable?"

Why this matters

The form's subtitle, framing copy, and section labels all use language that implies a job-seeker model (CV upload, 'target job description', 'employed / made redundant'). An entrepreneur considering a pivot into a new sector, or expanding into an adjacent business domain, would feel the form is not for them and may disengage. Yet the plan output is equally applicable to business pivots.

Recommended changes

Where	Current	Proposed change
Form subtitle	"Complete all sections below. Your responses will be compiled and emailed to your consultant."	Add a one-line scope note: "This form is for career changers, sector pivots, and entrepreneurs exploring a new domain."
CV upload label	"CV / Résumé (PDF recommended) *" (marked required)	Make optional and rename: "CV / Résumé or company profile (optional for entrepreneurs)" — with a helper note explaining the alternatives.
Section 3 org types	List ends at 'Startup'	No change needed — startup is already there. The issue is upstream framing, not the option list.
Target domain field	No helper text	Add placeholder hint: e.g. 'Fintech, Climate-focused NGOs, EdTech startup, Agribusiness pivot...' — signals that business pivots are valid entries.

Priority: MEDIUM

Affects the perceived target audience before a user even starts filling in the form. Copy changes only — no backend or logic impact.

7. Error Display — Raw HTML Shown to User on Submit Failure

Source

Jean's printed PDF — the final page shows the error message exactly as displayed.

What the user saw

When submission failed due to the CSRF issue, the form displayed the raw Flask HTTP error response directly inside the form's error box:

Displayed verbatim to the user:

```
Error: <!doctype html> <html lang=en> <title>400 Bad Request</title> <h1>Bad Request</h1> <p>The CSRF session token is missing.</p>
```

Fix

In **static/form.js**, the fetch error handler displays the raw server response text. It should instead check the HTTP status code and show a human-readable message. For a 400/403 CSRF error specifically, the message should instruct the user to refresh and try again:

Suggested user-facing message for a 400 response: "Your session has expired. Please refresh the page and resubmit — your answers will still be visible."

The fix lives entirely in **static/form.js** — no backend changes needed. The fetch response handler should branch on `response.ok` and `response.status` rather than passing raw text to the DOM.

Priority: HIGH

Technical error messages surfaced to end users are a UX failure and can cause distrust. This fix also makes session-expiry recoverable — users are told to refresh rather than abandoning.

8. Cold-Start Loading Screen — Server Logs Exposed to Client

Source

Additional tester — written feedback received 11 July 2026.

What was reported

When the application is accessed after a period of inactivity, Render's free-tier instance must restart from a cold state. During this restart period, Render's reverse proxy displays its own 'APPLICATION LOADING' page — a dark screen showing timestamped server log lines such as 'INCOMING HTTP REQUEST DETECTED', 'SERVICE WAKING UP', 'ALLOCATING COMPUTE RESOURCES', and 'ENVIRONMENT VARIABLES INJECTED'. The tester found this screen confusing and inappropriate for a client-facing professional service.

Tester's feedback (paraphrased):

"The loading of the form should not happen as the user sees the code. That screen should be replaced with a blank screen that gives an estimate of how long it will take for the form to complete loading."

Why this cannot be fixed from within the Flask app

Render's cold-start screen is served by Render's own reverse proxy infrastructure before the unicorn process binds to the port. No Flask route, template, or middleware can intercept or replace it — the application is not yet running when the screen is shown. A different architectural approach is required.

Solution implemented

A companion Render Static Site service was added alongside the Flask web service. Static sites on Render have no cold start and serve files instantly from Render's CDN. The loading page (**loading/index.html**) was created with the

following behaviour:

- Dark-theme branded screen matching the app's navy / teal / gold palette
- Spinner, animated progress bar, and a 40-second estimated countdown
- JavaScript polls the Flask app's `/_health` endpoint every 3 seconds
- Automatically redirects to the form once the health check returns 200
- Falls back to 'Still starting... almost there' copy once the countdown expires

A `/_health` endpoint was added to the Flask app returning `{"status": "ok"}` with an *Access-Control-Allow-Origin* header scoped to the loading site's origin (set via the `LOADING_SITE_ORIGIN` environment variable). The canonical client-facing URL is now the loading page; the Flask app URL is never shared directly.

Priority: HIGH — Status: RESOLVED

Server internals exposed to clients on first visit create a poor first impression and raise concerns about professionalism. The companion static site approach eliminates the issue entirely within the free tier. Implemented: 11 July 2026.

9. Summary Change Table

All findings from Round 1, ordered by priority. Each item includes the source tester, the affected component, the recommended action, and implementation status.

#	Finding	Source	Component	Action	Priority
1	SECRET_KEY not set on Render — CSRF tokens invalidated on every restart	Jean	Render env / app.py	Set SECRET_KEY in Render dashboard; redeploy	CRITICAL
2	'What attracts you to target domain?' precedes the target domain question	Jean	index.html — Section 2 & 3	Move question to Section 3, after 'Target domain / field'	HIGH
3	Raw HTML error shown on submit failure	Jean	static/form.js	Parse HTTP status; show user-friendly session-expiry message	HIGH
4	Cold-start loading screen exposes server logs to client	Additional tester	Render infra / render.yaml	Companion Render Static Site with branded loading page and /_health poller	HIGH
5	No question about preferred org lifecycle stage	Jean	index.html — Section 3	Add multi-select: Early startup / Growth startup / Established / Large / No preference	MEDIUM
6	Form appears corporate/job-market only — entrepreneurs feel excluded	Aida	index.html — framing copy	Add scope note to subtitle; make CV optional for entrepreneurs; add domain field hints	MEDIUM
7	Section 9 title 'Deliverable Preferences' is unclear	Jean	index.html — Section 9 header	Rename to 'About Your Plan'	LOW

Also noted (positive)

Jean specifically called out that answer-pointer hints beside each question (the helper text explaining why the question is asked) were useful: *"I like that pointers to answers are given. It helps the respondent keep on the right track and give relevant answers."* Retain this pattern in all future form iterations.